

The Best Places to Eat California Cuisine

Chez Panisse expensive

With California cuisine, a dish is only as good as its ingredients. A juicy heirloom tomato picked off the vine or a sweet summer squash becomes the catalyst for the meal, the natural flavors enhanced by light dressings, such as a tart lemon vinaigrette. Chef Alice Waters founded Chez Panisse – and California cuisine itself – in 1971 on the belief that fresh, sustainable cuisine should be a right, not a privilege. At Chez Panisse the seasons reign supreme, and menus are developed around what's fresh at the market. Summer warmth brings forth glossy berries, while the autumnal cool reaps broccoli, artichokes, and acorn squash. Typical dishes include mesclun salad studded with creamy spoonfuls of avocado, poached salmon drizzled with citrus vinaigrette, and guinea fowl in a Provençal tomato sauce. After a multi-course dinner here, you will believe in transformative culinary experiences.

1517 Shattuck Avenue, Berkeley; open for dinner (two sittings) 6–6:30 PM and 8:30–9:15 PM Mon–Thu; 6–6:30 PM and 8:30–9:30 PM Fri–Sat; www.chezpanisse.com

Also in San Francisco

California's most famous vegetarian restaurant, **Greens** (www.greensrestaurant.com; *moderate*) has a setting that matches the cuisine. Built in a spacious warehouse constructed of reclaimed wood, the floor-to-ceiling windows offer views of the Golden Gate Bridge and the Marin headlands. Greens opened in 1979 under the auspices of the San Francisco Zen Center, and it continues to uphold Buddhist philosophies while paving the way for vegetarian restaurants around the country. The seasonal menu includes mesquite-grilled brochettes of mushrooms, tofu, small potatoes, and white corn; spinach salad with red dandelion, feta, and croutons; and a rich summer squash ragout. For a high-end night out, try **Michael Mina** (www.michaelmina.net; *expensive*) where the eponymous celebrity chef showcases a creative menu based on organic ingredients, from diver-caught scallops with lemon-accented caviar to pulled pork with apple ravioli.

Also in the US

One of New York City's first organic restaurants, **GustOrganics** (www.gustorganics.com; *inexpensive*) serves superb Latino-inspired farm-fresh cuisine, with plentiful vegan, vegetarian, and gluten-free options from breakfast through dinner.

Around the World

Fresh, seasonal Italian cuisine is a staple at **Il Bocconcino** (www.ilbocconcino.com; *inexpensive*) in Rome. The restaurant is popular with followers of the "Slow Food" movement, which, like California cuisine, places a premium on locally sourced, organic produce.



Above Fresh figs drizzled in honey sum up the essence of California cuisine – sustainably grown ingredients of the highest quality

Left French-inspired but thoroughly Californian, Chez Panisse has become a culinary institution